15 Political Divisions of South India

Topics covered

- Summary of information
- Karnataka
- Andhra Pradesh
- Kerala
- Tamil Nadu & Union Territories of Puducherry
- Andaman and Nicobar Islands
- Lakshadweep Islands

Identify these states and union territories in this map. Talk about what kind of geographical form they have. There may be more than one.

Karnataka Andaman & Nicobar Islands Andhra Pradesh Lakshadweep
Kerala Puducherry Tamil Nadu

The states and union territories of south India have very varied geography. The weather here is hot and some parts get heavy rain. The states south of the river Krishna are the ones you will read about in this chapter. See a brief summary of them in the table.

States/UT	Capital and other cities	Rivers	Natural vegetation	Crops	Occupation
Karnataka	Bengaluru—capital, Mysuru, Mangaluru	Kaveri, Krishna, Tungabhadra	Forests, with deciduous trees, scrub vegetation and coconut palms	Coffee, rice, ragi, pulses, groundnuts, sandalwood	Farming, IT industry, silk production

States/UT	Capital and other cities	Rivers	Natural vegetation	Crops	Occupation
Andhra Pradesh	Hyderabad—capital, Amaravati, Vijayawada, Tirupati, Vishakapatnam	Krishna, Penneru, Godavari	Mangrove swamps, forests, thorny plants	Rice, millets, chillies, tobacco, groundnuts	Farming, fishing, working in industries, handicrafts
Kerala	Thiruvanan-thapuram—capital, Kochi	Periyar, Pamba, Ponnai backwaters	Coconut palm groves, rainforests, grasslands	Rice, rubber, tapioca, cashew, spices, coffee, tea	Farming, **coir** and wood products, IT industry
Tamil Nadu	Chennai—capital, Coimbatore, Madurai, Udhagamandalam	Vaigai, Kaveri, Palar, Ponnaiyar	Forests , deciduous and evergreen trees	Rice, sugar cane , millets, groundnuts, chillies, cashewnuts	Farming, working in factories and offices, handicrafts, textiles
Puducherry	Puducherry—capital	Kaveri, Mahe, branch of Godavari		Rice, sugar cane, groundnuts, millets	Farming, tourism
Andaman & Nicobar Islands	Port Blair—capital	Small streams	Forests, mangrove swamps	Rice, coconut, rubber, cashew	Farming, fishing, tourism
Lakshadweep Islands	Kavaratti—capital		Coconut palms, casuarina and tamarind trees	Jackfruit, banana, wild almond, drumstick	Coconut products, fishing, tourism

KARNATAKA

Capital and other cities: Bengaluru is the capital city of this state. It is also called the Garden City because of the many parks and gardens here. Other cities are Mysuru, known for its beautiful Mysore palace and Mangaluru, which is a port city.

Rivers: The Krishna, the Kaveri and the Tungabhadra are the important rivers that flow through the state.

The stone chariot of the Vittala Temple at Hampi—the ruins here are a World Heritage Site.

Natural vegetation: The state has mixed vegetation based on the land. There are forests that have deciduous trees, such as sandalwood. There is scrub vegetation in the drier areas of the state. Coconut palms line the coastal areas.

Rice fields of Karnataka

Crops: Coffee, ragi, groundnuts, rice and pulses are the main crops. Sandalwood trees are also grown for their expensive and sweet-smelling wood. This is used to make incense sticks, perfumes and soaps.

Occupation: Most of the people in the rural areas are farmers. Those in the city work in offices and factories. The IT industry has people from all over the country working here. Silk production is also an important occupation.

ANDHRA PRADESH

Capital and other cities: Hyderabad is the capital city. It is shared with Telangana which was earlier part of a larger Andhra Pradesh. However, Amaravati is being developed as a capital city for the future. Other important cities are Vishakhapatnam, a port city, and Vijayawada, situated on the banks of the river Krishna. Tirupati is a very popular temple town.

Prakasam Barrage built over the river Krishna at Vijayawada

Nandi bull built out of a single granite rock at Veerabhadra Temple, Lepakshi village

Rivers: The rivers Krishna, Godavari and Penneru flow through various parts of the state.

Natural vegetation: There are mangrove swamps and palm trees along the coastline. The dry plateau region has thorny vegetation. The land that is part of the Eastern Ghats has wet forests with teak, rosewood and bamboo. Neem trees and flowering plants are also found in plenty.

Crops: Rice, millets, chillies, groundnuts and tobacco are the main crops grown.

Occupation: As in most parts of the country, people in rural areas are farmers. Since the state has minerals, people also work in the mining industry. Fishing is an important occupation in the coastal areas. Seafood cultivation like prawn farming is also done here. Handicrafts like metalwork, vegetable dyes and leather puppets are also an occupation for many people.

KERALA

Capital and other cities: The state is often called 'God's own country' because of its beautiful green landscape and network of waterways. Its capital is Thiruvananthapuram. Kochi is another important city, known for its history and business activities.

A houseboat on the backwaters—Kerala has almost 2,000 kilometres of waterways!

Rivers: The Ponnai, Periyar and Pamba are among the main rivers. These, along with waters from the lakes and seas, form a network of waterways, called the **backwaters**. The backwaters criss-cross the state and are used for transport. They also extend all along the coastline and form a natural transport system.

Think and answer

Why are waterways an important means of transport within Kerala?

Natural vegetation: The coastline being wet and watery has abundant coconut palm **groves** (small group of trees). The areas of the Western Ghats and the river regions have deciduous forests and rainforests. Grasslands are found in the other regions.

Traditional fishing nets used in Kochi—poles are fixed on the beach and the nets pulled up with ropes.

Crops: The main crops are coconut, rubber, rice and **tapioca** (the root of the cassava plant that looks like a brown sweet potato). The state also grows a lot of spices like pepper and cardamom. Coffee and tea are grown in the higher areas.

Occupation: Farming and occupations based on agriculture, are the main ones. IT industries are now coming up. Making **coir** (coir=rough fibre of the coconut) products like mats and bags is an important industry. The state is also well known for making handicrafts of rosewood.

TAMIL NADU

Capital and other cities: Chennai, the capital city, is on the coast of the Bay of Bengal. Other important towns are Coimbatore known for its small industries and textiles, Madurai which is a temple town and Udhagamandalam (also called Ooty) a popular hill town.

The giant balancing rock, also known as Krishna's butter ball, is a tourist attraction at Mamallapuram, which is also famous for its rock temples.

Rivers: The Kaveri, Vaigai, Palar and the Ponnaiyar are the major rivers of this state.

Natural vegetation: There are some forests in the higher areas of the Western Ghats. To the east of the Western Ghats, and in some other parts, the land has a mixture of evergreen and deciduous trees.

Sunrise at Triveni Sangam (meeting of three waters of the Indian Ocean, Bay of Bengal and Arabian Sea) at Kanniyakumari

Crops: Main crops grown are rice, millets, groundnuts and sugar cane. Cotton, chillies and cashewnuts are also important.

Occupation: Agriculture and fishing are important occupations. The state also has many industries and factories where people work. Factories manufacturing train coaches, thermal power plants, mining, textile mills, government and private offices and handicraft centres are some of the places where people work.

THE UNION TERRITORY OF PUDUCHERRY

This union territory is close to Chennai and is a popular tourist centre. It was formed by combining four French colonies in 1962—Pondicherry (renamed Puducherry), Karaikal, Yanam and Mahe. Puducherry is the capital of this territory.

Puducherry is on the Coromandel Coast and has canals dividing the city. The river Kaveri drains the Karaikal region, the Mahe River waters the Mahe region and Yanam is on the banks of a branch of the Godavari River. Together they make the region suitable for growing crops. Rice, sugar cane, groundnuts and millets are grown.

The golden dome of Matrimandir (temple of The Mother) at Auroville, Puducherry

Puducherry is a popular tourist spot for its sandy beaches, old French settlements, churches and temples as well as the Aurobindo Ashram and Matrimandir.

ANDAMAN AND NICOBAR ISLANDS

This union territory is made up of two archipelagos in the Indian Ocean. The Nicobar Islands lie south of the Andamans. Port Blair, in the Andaman Islands, is the capital of this territory.

The Cellular Jail in Port Blair had several hundred small cells, in which the British imprisoned people during the freedom struggle. It is now a National Memorial.

Being an island region, there are no flowing rivers but Nicobar has some small streams in the slightly higher regions that provide fresh water. The frequent rains help dense forests and mangrove swamps to grow.

Did you Know?

India's only active volcano is in the Andaman Islands—in Barren Island. The volcano erupted very strongly in 1991 after being dormant for almost 200 years. The hot lava destroyed the forests and animals on land and in water. Since then it erupts every two to three years, the last as recently as January 2017.

Crops like rice, coconuts, cashew, rubber and fruit are also grown, mainly by the local tribal people who live in the smaller islands. Fishing and furniture making are

other occupations. Port Blair has people from other cities who work there. Many islands are visited only by tourists. Havelock Island is a popular tourist attraction.

Scuba diving—people wear special equipment and dive into the sea to see the beautiful underwater life in the clear waters. Notice the different coloured coral.

LAKSHADWEEP ISLANDS

Another group of islands that is also a union territory lies in the Arabian Sea. It is called the Lakshadweep islands. The name means—one lakh islands, but there are about 36 coral islands. Kavaratti is the capital city located on an island of the same name.

Most of the people are settlers who moved from the western coast of India many centuries ago.

Coconut palms, casuarina, and tamarind are some trees that grow on the island. People also grow wild almond, jackfruit, banana and drumstick.

Making coconut products and fishing are the major occupations—as also is tourism. The islands are an attraction for their clear waters, scuba-diving and the vast variety of underwater life.

Discuss

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Can you find two similarities and two differences between the two island union territories?

Values and Life Skills

- Why is it important to preserve the natural marine life—the creatures and plants that live in the seas—in the waters of our oceans?
- Why is swimming an important skill for people who live near water?

REMEMBER

1. The southern states have very varied geography.
2. Rivers provide water to crops. The two archipelagos have no rivers.
3. Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu have industries.
4. The two union territories are archipelagos.

NEW WORDS

Barrage	wall or barrier across a river to prevent flooding
Backwaters	part of the river or sea where the water does not flow
Tapioca	root of the cassava plant that is very starchy
Coir	fibre from the outer shell of the coconut

EXERCISES

A. Fill in the blanks.

1. A World Heritage site in Karnataka .....
2. A river over which the Prakasam Barrage is built .....
3. A starchy crop grown widely in Kerala .....
4. A hill town in Tamil Nadu .....
5. A temple that has a golden dome .....
6. Important historical spot in the Andamans .....
7. A group of coral islands .....

B. Unscramble the names of capital cities and states and then match the following.

Nos	Capitals	Unscrambled	Unscrambled	States
1.	ropt lraib			yhrrcedupu
2.	ravakitta			milta duna
3.	varupamiruththanan			damnaans
4.	decrhyruup			narkakata
5.	dabredahy			peedwkalash
6.	hcninae			radhan eshrapd
7.	garuluenb			lareka

C. Who am I?

1. The Garden City of south India .....
2. A state that shares it capital with a newly formed state in 2014.....
3. God's own country .....
4. A giant balancing rock:.....
5. A union territory that is made up of two archipelagos .....

D. Write true or false.

Correct the false sentences in your notebook.

1. The beautiful Mysore Palace is located in Kerala.
2. Vishakhapatnam is a port city.
3. The backwaters form a network for water transport in Kerala.
4. Kanniyakumari lies at the confluence of the Krishna, Godavari and Pamba.
5. Puducherry was formed by combining Mahe, Ross Island, Udhagamandalam and Kavaratti.

E. Answer the following questions.

1. Sandalwood trees are sometimes stolen in Karnataka. Why do you think this is so?
2. Name some of the handicrafts in Andhra Pradesh.
3. Why is Kerala called 'God's own country'?
4. What are some of the tourist attractions in the union territories of India?
5. Where are the Lakshadweep Islands located?
6. What is scuba-diving? Where is it popular and why?

THINGS TO DO

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A. Picture study

These are coconut trees, fishing nets and rice fields. How do they affect the life of the people in south India?

B. On your own

Find out about the following: Cellular Jail and Ross Island in the Andamans, Bora Bora caves in Vishakhapatnam, rock structures in Mamallapuram, Gol Gumbaz in Karnataka, Periyar Sanctuary in Kerala, the Ujra Mosque in Lakshadweep, churches in Puducherry

TP

C. In a group

Make seven groups. Put together all the information about the states and the union territories in each group. Add more interesting information that you can get. Share the information that you have together.

WEBLINK

Scuba diving in the Andaman Islands:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=efPbWqq9UAM (accessed on 16 Aug 2017)